

Too dumb for a smartphone?

Increasing device complexity is no laughing matter

Rashmi Bansal

*There was once a man with a cell
He loved it wisely and well
Then he traded it in
For a shiny new thing
And now he is going thru hell!*

Sounds familiar? It's the story of every second person who decides to 'upgrade' to a new, feature-packed cellphone.

One day you are perfectly happy with your trusty two-year-old handset—it does the two things that a phone really needs to do, call and SMS! The next, you are seduced by a younger, slimmer model packed with a dozen oh-so-cool features.

You feel vaguely guilty about coughing up Rs 20,000 for a palm sized contraption—an amount that could buy you a full size fridge, two 21-inch colour TVs, or three microwaves! But when was there ever a sense of logic in lust?

Two months later, the passion cools. Your new companion's *asli roop* is now evident—high on maintenance, low on efficiency. The phone is too complicated to use! And no, this conclusion isn't a case of sour grapes—I speak not from envy, but from experience.

Take the simple task of text messaging. On my ancient Nokia 3310 it took three lightning quick finger flicks. On my new Nokia 6670, initially it took me six keypresses, and not all the buttons were close enough for comfort. Eventually, I learnt to do it in four, and then, hallelujah, I discovered a one touch option.

OK, so I didn't—a junior office colleague who happens to be an alpha geek figured it out for me. He's the kind of guy *Wired* magazine would describe as 'technosexual'. The difference between technosexuals and ordinary mortals can be summed up in three quick observations:

☐ Technosexuals are never 'too lazy' to read user manuals—even if they are the size of telephone directories, which is what smartphones will soon be accompanied by!

☐ 'Fiddling around' is harmless fun for technosexuals. Ordinary mortals end up deleting their



Illustration Shyam Sriram

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phonebooks, and no, we don't have backups!

☐ Technosexuals love complexity. The rest of humanity just gives up.

This is a species which will skimp on everything else, but own the latest, jazziest gizmo. One such member of the geekerati, a student I know, has a call centre job. He sports a Rs 30,000 Sony Ericsson S700i, but isn't concerned about the holes in his socks.

The engineers who design smartphones probably share this profile. And so, they end up designing instruments that are compatible with folks like themselves.

So why did I buy a smartphone? Partly because of peer pressure. I had the oldest and ugliest phone amongst anyone I knew—partially chipped after kissing the ground a few hundred times. But mainly, I picked up the Nokia 6670 for its one-megapixel camera. The with-you-at-all-times factor made the camera phone a must have.

Although I must say I am pretty satisfied with its picture quality, the same can't be said about the way the camera functions. It does not respond as rapidly as a conventional digital camera. What's more, downloading the pictures is a pain. The data cable just refused to connect the computer and

phone. A simple but maddening case of loose connections.

To make matters worse, some of the pictures got mysteriously corrupted. Eventually, the entire multimedia card (MMC) died. It most likely needs to be formatted, and of course, all the stuff on it I tried to back up will be lost forever.

Connecting to GPRS was another nightmare. Simply saving the settings sent by my cellphone provider was not enough. I had to actually visit the provider's store where an executive explained that my phone required 'advanced' settings. Hidden somewhere deep inside the menu!

Is it any wonder that a recent survey in Europe found that 85 per cent of consumers admitted to being 'too dumb' to access or use mobile services—mainly due to increasing device complexity? Nearly three quarters feel that handsets have become 'too difficult to navigate'. Another study found 30 per cent of participants rated 'not knowing what features are available' as their top complaint.

Bottomline: There's so much packed into the average smartphone that basics often take a backseat. On the Nokia 6670, the green and red buttons generally used for making and ending calls are designed for a circus midget's fingers! And yet, overall, these phones are generally bigger and bulkier than average—you don't get that comfy palm-fit feeling.

I guess the first generation of smartphone users will be the *bakras* who will help companies figure out what is it that people really want. In the interim, they need to help users figure out what the technology in their hands can really do. I mean, if refrigerator companies can send a guy home to give a 'demo' (I kid you not!), surely handset makers can do the same?

Until then, scream for help! There are always alpha geeks lurking, dying to rescue the 'damn cell in distress'.

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